Needs and Support, Side by Side

A family worksheet for who does what for Mom, who else could, and what's still an open question.

“We've got it covered” is a feeling. “The neighbor drives on Tuesdays and keeps the appointment card on her fridge” is a picture, and a picture is something the whole family can look at together.

Fill this in over a few visits and phone calls, not in one sitting. Start each line with the task, so the sections match up. Put the date at the top. Where you don't know, write “not sure” and leave it.

What Mom gets help with, and how you know

One thing to a line, in plain words, the small things included. After each, note where it comes from and when: you were there, Mom told you, your brother mentioned it.

FOR EXAMPLE Rides to appointments: Mom told me, last month. Bills: my brother said at Easter that he's had them since last year. Evening call: that one's me.

Who does each one now, and how often

A family member, a neighbor, a friend, Mom herself. Add the day, the time and any detail that makes it work.

FOR EXAMPLE Rides: the neighbor, in her car, whenever there's an appointment. She keeps the appointment card on her fridge. Evening call: me, around seven.

Who else could do it

Next to each task, someone else who knows how and has the time. Where there's no one, write “only them.” Where you don't know, write “not sure.”

FOR EXAMPLE Bills: only my brother. Nobody else knows which ones come when. Rides: not sure. My cousin drives, and nobody has asked her.

Backups: agreed, or assumed

Every backup the family mentions. Write “agreed” if that person has said yes, “assumed” if nobody has asked them, and who you heard it from. If three of you say the same thing because you all heard it from Mom, that's one account, not three.

FOR EXAMPLE “Aunt Carol would step in with the driving”: assumed. My brother said it, he heard it from Mom, and nobody has asked Aunt Carol.

What's still an open question

A task with no second name, a line you can't confirm, or something in Mom's week that is done only some of the time. Write each one as a question, and note whether you saw it recently or are going from memory.

FOR EXAMPLE Does she still get to her Thursday card game? I think her ride changed. From memory; I'll ask her on Sunday.

In Mom's own words

How the arrangement looks from her side. Write what she says, the way she says it, and keep it separate from everyone else's account.

FOR EXAMPLE “I don't like asking her for a ride unless it's the doctor.”

What this shows you

Three things: what Mom gets help with as far as the family knows, which tasks have one name beside them, and which backups someone has actually agreed to. It doesn't show whether her arrangement is enough or whether anything should change. Nothing here adds up to a score, and a line that says “only them” or “assumed” is something to ask about, not a finding. Questions about her health or her medications go to her doctor or pharmacist.

Ready for the next step?

You've put who does what for Mom on paper, with the open questions left open. The care interview picks up from there: it goes through her daily life area by area, so the parts nobody thought to list come up too, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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